

GOD LIES IN THE DETAIL

SPIRITUAL ART FORM ■ KOOTIYATTAM, KERALA

UNESCO called for its preservation, describing it as "a masterpiece of the oral and intangible heritage of humanity." Based on Bharata Muni's *Natyashastra*, Kootiyattam dates back to the 9th century, which makes it the oldest surviving art form in India. What is special is that it can be performed only by people from certain communities—the male roles essayed by Chakkiars and the female roles by Nangiars. Kootiyattam—from which the more popular Kathakali has evolved—literally means 'playing or dancing together'. Initially performed in Kootampalams, designated theatre spaces inside temples in Kerala, it has today moved into auditoriums across the globe. Only one section of an act is performed in a night, with the entire play taking up to 40 nights. Though the dialogue is limited to a few lines of Sanskrit poetry, each line is illuminated by hours of detailing—a chakkiair playing Krishna can elaborate on Radha's eyes for a whole night. In today's fast-paced world, it is reassuring that such beauty is achieved by these artistes in the quest for spiritual perfection through performance.

by Nirmala Ravindran

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